

BLUE LABEL
The Water Metro's electric boat leaves the Vypeen jetty

ANI

KOCHI WATER METRO

A UNIQUE WATER MARK

By Jeemon Jacob

Prime Minister Narendra Modi made another whirlwind trip to Kerala in the last week of April where he flagged off two pathbreaking projects, the state's first Vande Bharat semi-high speed express train and the inland Water Metro. The latter is an integrated ferry transport system which will cater to the Greater Kochi region.

The business capital of Kerala is the first city in India to get this unique traffic commuter facility. Some 10 islands on the outer reaches of its coastal archipelago, slung along a complicated map of estuaries and backwaters and hence a logistical headache in terms of road commute, will be connected. Doing the honours will be a fleet of 78 battery-operated electric hybrid boats, flitting to and fro between 38 terminals with intelligent navigation systems, on 15 routes that together span about 78 km.

The Rs 1,137 crore project impressed in its first ride on April 25. Among the first passengers were a number of disabled children and their parents who travelled from Vypeen to the High Court jetty on the mainland. While launching the project, PM Modi extolled the Kerala government initiative to introduce a ferry service which is eco-friendly and a viable answer to the traffic chaos in Kochi.

Chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan expressed hope on the occasion that the novel initiative would contribute to the development of the tourism sector in Kerala. The project, executed by Kerala Metro Rail Ltd and partly funded through an €85 million (Rs 763.1 crore) loan from the Indo-German Financial Corporation will be completed by 2035. In the first phase, operations have started in two sectors—the Vypeen-High Court and Vytilla-Kakkanad routes.

The greater Kochi metropolitan area, where 10 per cent of Kerala's 33.4 million population lives, has been dogged with traffic chaos for a very long time now. The Kochi Metro Rail started operations in June 2017, but traffic woes continue to haunt the city. That situation may be alleviated to some extent by the water ferry. "It will transform Kochi into a better living space. It's a safe, modern means of transport offering better connectivity to remote islanders with the cheapest possible fares," says Prof. K.V. Thomas, former MP and now special representative of the Kerala government in New Delhi. The air-conditioned boats can seat about 50-100 and are expected to carry 34,000 people daily when the first phase is complete. Ticket prices start at Rs 20 and go up to Rs 40. Commuters certainly seem to have taken a fancy to it. Less than a week after operations started, daily ridership had already crossed the 10,000 mark.

"We are thrilled with the response from the people. Kochi Water Metro has shown India how the state can provide world-class facilities to city-dwellers and ease their commuting woes, especially since a single Metro fare payment integrates travel by both boat and train," says Loknath Behera, CEO of Kochi Rail Metro Ltd and its subsidiary, Water Metro Ltd.

